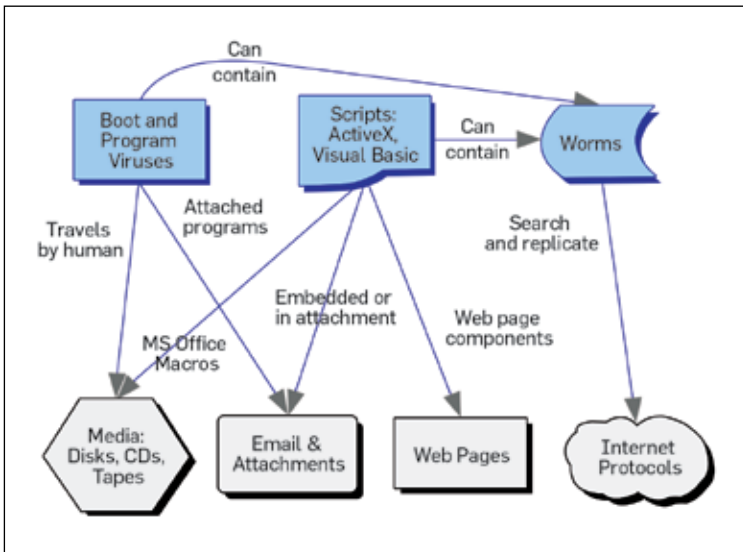




A simple diagram to show how malware can propagate

How does this happen? Well, the malicious code or virus is inserted into the chain of command so that when the infected program is run, the viral code is also executed (or in some cases, runs instead of the legitimate program). Viruses are usually seen as extraneous code attached to a host program, but this isn't always the case. Sometimes, the environment is manipulated so that calling a legitimate uninfected program calls the viral program. The viral program may also be executed before any other program is run. This can virtually infect every executable file on the computer, even though none of those files' code was actually tampered with. Viruses that follow this modus operandi include "cluster" or "FAT" (File Allocation Table) viruses, which redirect system pointers to infected files, associate viruses and viruses that modify the Windows Registry directory entries so that their own code is executed before any other legitimate program.

Computer viruses usually spread via removable media or the internet. A flash disk, CD-ROM, magnetic tape or other storage device that has been in an infected computer infects all future computers in which it's used. Your computer can also contract viruses from sinister email attachments, rogue web sites or infected software. And these disseminate to every other computer on your network.